

3. Methods

The systematic literature review aimed to determine the current scenario of public reporting research and the different parties involved in the healthcare industry. To that goal, we investigated the six particular research questions (RQs) indicated in [Table 1](#).

Table 1. Research questions.

Number	Research question
RQ1 ^a	What is the present status of the research on public reporting in the health ca
RQ2	What are the most important publication channels?
RQ3	What research methods have been used?
RQ4	What theoretical backgrounds and variables have been employed?
RQ5	What recurring research themes can be identified from the literature?
RQ6	What future research directions can be synthesized from the literature?

^aRQ: research question.

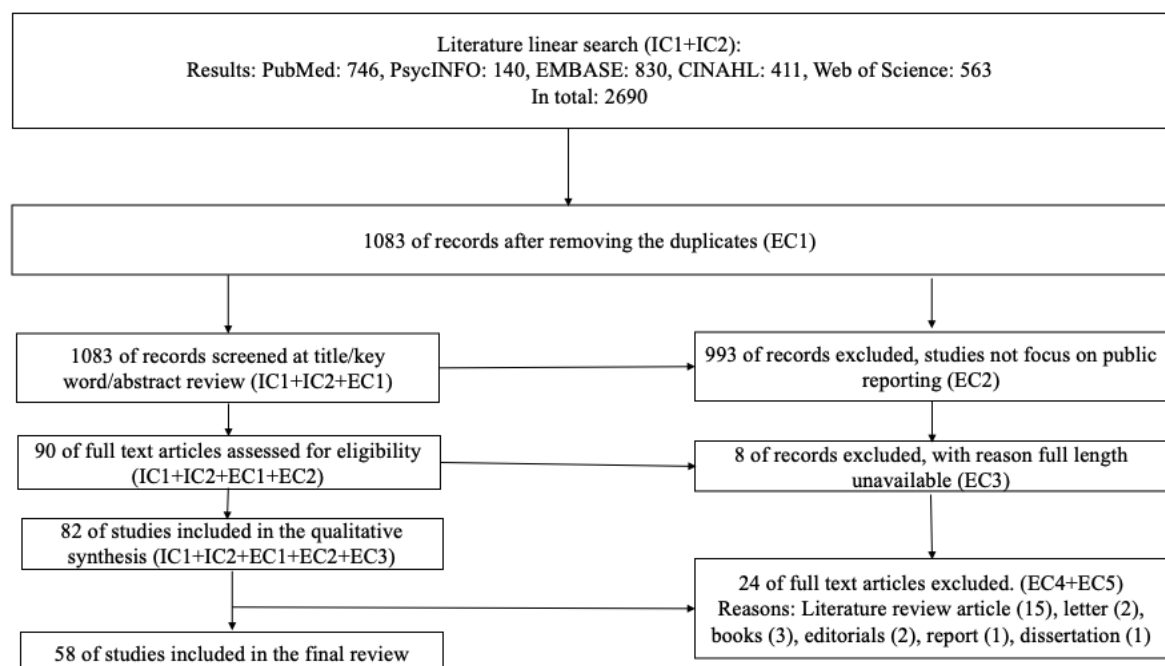
Research Design

A research literature review is "a systematic, explicit, and reproducible method for identifying, evaluating, and synthesizing the existing body of completed and recorded work produced by researchers, scholars, and practitioners" (Fink, 2013), which typically aims to identify new future research areas, facilitating theory development, closing saturated research areas, and categorizing and classifying studies in specific research streams (Okoli, 2015; vom Brocke et al., 2015; Webster & Watson, 2002). Since public reporting is crucial to hospital performance, a 2016 Health Affairs study found that no hospital received a high rating from any of the four major national rating systems: Consumer Reports, Leapfrog, Healthgrades, and U.S. News & World Report (Austin et al., 2015). Hospitals should be aware of the current state of public quality reporting, as well as hospital and physician ratings and data sources, and reporting transparency. This paper conducts a systematic literature review of public reporting in the healthcare field. This type of literature review summarizes previous knowledge and identifies gaps in a specific area of research (Paré et al., 2015). This paper closely follows the guidelines suggested by Webster and Watson (2002) and Okoli (2015) to

conduct a systematic literature review and ensure that the results are clear, comprehensive, and replicable.

Based on the current work's topic of public reporting in the health care area. First, articles were obtained from five academic databases: PubMed, PsycInfo, EMBASE, CINAHL and Web of Science (WoS), which dominate the health, biomedicine, psychology and medicine were selected to search for eligible studies as widely as possible. These databases was accessed via the school library to check that the user had logged in, preventing missing articles owing to users failing to log in to the school account. The number of search phrases for each database was recorded to verify that the logarithm of each subsequent step was correct. To search for articles as broadly as possible and prevent missing items during the search process, the number of search results, downloads for each database, and imports into the Endnote software were all tracked. The language restriction was set to English during the search to allow the general public to query and refer to it at any moment. Figure 1 depicts the phases in article retrieval as well as the amounts of articles.

Figure 1. Literature search steps. IC: inclusion criterion; EC: exclusion criterion.



Second, the following search terms were applied to search titles and abstracts of articles and to find subject-specific articles for the literature review: (“healthcare,” “health care,”) and (“public reporting,”). The current study’s authors searched 2690 publications in total, of which 746 in Pubmed, 563 in WoS, 411 in CINAHL, 830 in Embase and 140 in PsycInfo. By importing into endnote software to delete duplicates, then manually remove duplicates and read the title to double-check for omissions.

Third, articles’ abstracts, keywords, and titles were screened across the five databases based on the above keywords. The further screening of the 1083 articles for inclusion and exclusion was based on the inclusion and exclusion criteria in a two-step process. In the fourth step of applying practical screening criteria, the inclusion criteria and exclusion criteria has been shown in table 1. The literature review first screened the title and abstract of these 1083 articles to select articles to decide whether they concerned research on public reporting and then looked through the title/key words/abstract selected for forward and backward checking. After reading the abstracts and titles, 993 records were excluded for not matching the inclusion criteria (studies with the main topic (title/abstract/keywords) containing public report, studies available in English). In screening the titles of the 1,083 retrieved articles, the screening step includes whether the titles of these 1,083 articles contain the keyword "public report". If the title is unclear, read the abstract to discover if the research focusses on public reporting. If it just mentions public reporting, for example, if the article gives the recommendation to pay attention to public reporting or the article uses public reporting data to investigate other study, it should also be excluded.

Table 1. Inclusion and exclusion criteria

Inclusion criteria (IC)

IC1: Studies published in English

IC2: Studies with the main topic (title/abstract) containing public report

IC3: Full-texts of studies

IC4: Studies published in journals or scientific conference

Exclusion criteria (EC)

EC1: Eliminate duplicate studies from different searches

EC2: Studies whose main topic is not public reporting (Studies not focus on public reporting means that even if the abstract mentions public reporting, the article is not about public reporting).

EC3: Full text unavailable (studies were incomplete).

EC4: Studies that are not empirical studies (books, editorials, report, letters)

EC5: Literature review article

By further not fulfilling the inclusion criteria at the analysis level of full text, 8 articles were excluded, leaving 82 studies.

Forth, the types of articles were screened, the remaining 82 articles were screened in full text to determine whether they met inclusion criteria 4 (studies published in journals and conference proceedings), excluding 15 literature reviews and 9 conceptual papers (letter 2, books 3, editorials 2, report 1, dissertation 1) that did not contain any empirical analysis. Reviews and letters were excluded because they were not reporting original data.

In addition, 58 articles were read and analyzed in full. Their research methods and theories, research equipment, and research contexts were identified to establish a general understanding of these studies.

The search string had wide coverage to avoid missing any research of interest. In our search, there were no restrictions on publication time or study design. Studies published in languages other than English were excluded. The search strategy for each database is shown in Table 2, and the detailed explanation of these search strategies is provided.

Table 2. Databases and search terms

Database	Search terms
PubMed (746)	("healthcare"[Title/Abstract] OR "health care"[Title/Abstract]) AND "public report*" [Title/Abstract]
PsycInfo (140)	(TI healthcare OR AB healthcare OR TI "health care" OR AB "health care") AND (TI "public report*" OR AB "public report*")
EMBASE (830)	(healthcare OR "health care"):ab,ti AND (("public report*"):ab,ti)
CINAHL (411)	(TI healthcare OR AB healthcare OR TI "health care" OR AB "health care") AND (TI "public report*" OR AB "public report*")
Web of science (563)	(TI=(healthcare OR "health care") OR AB=(healthcare OR "health care")) AND (TI="public report*" OR AB="public report*")

Finally, 58 articles were selected as the final sample.

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